

A counterexample to Erdős Problem 1075

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Abstract

Erdős asked whether, for every fixed $r \geq 3$, there is a constant $c_r > r^{-r}$ such that, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, every sufficiently large r -uniform hypergraph on N vertices with at least $(1 + \varepsilon)(N/r)^r$ edges contains a subgraph on $m \rightarrow \infty$ vertices with at least $c_r m^r$ edges. We give counterexamples for every $r \geq 8$. The base construction is a sequence of explicit 8-uniform hypergraphs G_n whose unnormalized Lagrangians satisfy

$$8^{-8} \left(1 + \frac{1}{4(6n)^6} \right) \leq \lambda(G_n) \leq 8^{-8} + \frac{1}{7!n}.$$

Blow-ups give the counterexample for $r = 8$, and adjoining common vertices to every edge lifts it to all larger uniformities. Thus Problem 1075, as a statement for all $r \geq 3$, has a negative answer. The endpoint question remains open for $3 \leq r \leq 7$, including the case $2/9$ for 3-graphs.

1 Introduction

All hypergraphs in this paper are finite and simple. For a hypergraph H , write $v(H) = |V(H)|$, $e(H) = |E(H)|$, and let $H[S]$ denote the subgraph induced by $S \subseteq V(H)$.

Erdős proved that, for every fixed $r \geq 2$ and $\varepsilon > 0$, an r -uniform hypergraph on N vertices with at least εN^r edges contains a complete r -partite r -uniform hypergraph with equal part sizes tending to infinity with N [1]. In particular, it contains a subgraph on $m \rightarrow \infty$ vertices with $(m/r)^r$ edges. Erdős subsequently conjectured that, for each fixed $r \geq 3$, there is a constant $c_r > r^{-r}$ such that, for every $\varepsilon > 0$ and all sufficiently large N , the assumption

$$e(H) \geq (1 + \varepsilon)(N/r)^r$$

forces a subgraph on $m = m(N) \rightarrow \infty$ vertices with at least $c_r m^r$ edges [3, p. 80]. This is Problem 1075 in Bloom's collection [13].

With the usual density $d(H) = e(H)/\binom{v(H)}{r}$, the threshold $(N/r)^r$ corresponds asymptotically to $\alpha_r = r!/r^r$. Erdős proved that every number in $[0, \alpha_r)$ is a jump for r -graphs [2]. Thus Problem 1075 is the endpoint question at α_r . Frankl and Rödl disproved the earlier jumping constant conjecture by constructing non-jumps for every $r \geq 3$ [4]. Frankl, Peng, Rödl and Talbot later showed that $(5/2)r!/r^r$ is a non-jump for every $r \geq 3$ [5], and Peng proved the lifting theorem that carries a non-jump of the form $cr!/r^r$ to all larger uniformities [6]. Yan and Peng proved that $12/25$ is a non-jump for 3-graphs, yielding $(54/25)r!/r^r$ for every $r \geq 3$ by lifting [7].

Shaw recently proved that $2r!/r^r$ is a non-jump for every $r \geq 4$, and that for $r \geq 4$ no smaller non-jump can be obtained from his finite-pattern formulation of the Frankl–Rödl method [8, Theorems 4.2 and 4.3]. Liu and Mubayi subsequently proved that $4/9$ is a non-jump for 3-graphs by a construction outside that finite-pattern framework [9]. The endpoint $2/9$ for 3-graphs remains

open; Baber and Talbot proved, using flag algebras, the first jump intervals immediately above it [10]. The result below shows that the endpoint is a non-jump for every $r \geq 8$; the cases $3 \leq r \leq 7$ remain open.

The construction below is not an instance of Shaw's finite-pattern criterion. Its distinguished links between the two vertex families follow the matching $A_i B_i$ and the shifted matching $B_i A_{i+1}$ around a cycle, and the proof controls the full Lagrangian of a growing sequence G_n . Hence Shaw's Theorem 4.3 does not apply.

Theorem 1. *For every $\gamma > 8^{-8}$, there is an $\varepsilon > 0$ and there are arbitrarily large 8-uniform hypergraphs H such that*

$$e(H) \geq (1 + \varepsilon)(v(H)/8)^8, \quad e(H[S]) < \gamma|S|^8 \quad \text{for every nonempty } S \subseteq V(H).$$

The conclusion is stronger than the formulation of Problem 1075, since the bound holds for every nonempty vertex subset. Taking $8^{-8} < \gamma < c_8$ in Theorem 1 rules out any $c_8 > 8^{-8}$. In the usual density normalization, it also implies that $8!/8^8$ is a non-jump. The proof uses explicit finite hypergraphs whose Lagrangians approach 8^{-8} from above. We use the standard unnormalized Lagrangian [11, 12],

$$P_H(x) = \sum_{e \in E(H)} \prod_{v \in e} x_v, \quad \lambda(H) = \max_{\substack{x_v \geq 0 \\ \sum_v x_v = 1}} P_H(x), \quad (1.1)$$

without the factor $r!$.

Proposition 2. *For every integer $n \geq 2$, the 8-uniform hypergraph G_n defined in Section 2 has $2n + 13$ vertices and satisfies*

$$8^{-8} \left(1 + \frac{1}{4(6n)^6}\right) \leq \lambda(G_n) \leq 8^{-8} + \frac{1}{7!n}. \quad (1.2)$$

The mechanism is visible at the level of the cubic forms. After normalizing the bottom mass, the balanced weighting on the closed cycle has

$$b_i + c = B - b_i + D = a_{i+1} + c = A - a_{i+1} + D = \frac{1}{3},$$

so both cubic forms attain $1/27$ even with $D > 0$, while the additional edge $\{U, V\} \cup \mathcal{D}$ contributes a gain of order D^6 . Deleting one pair A_k, B_k opens the cycle; the terminal mismatch forces a loss of order D^3 , which dominates that gain. Consequently every open path T_L has Lagrangian exactly 8^{-8} , whereas the closed cycle has Lagrangian slightly above 8^{-8} .

2 The cyclic construction

Fix $n \geq 2$. Take pairwise distinct vertices

$$A_i, B_i \quad (i \in \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}), \quad C, U, V, \quad W_1, \dots, W_4, \quad D_1, \dots, D_6.$$

Put $\mathcal{W} = \{W_1, \dots, W_4\}$ and $\mathcal{D} = \{D_1, \dots, D_6\}$. On the vertex set $\{A_i, B_i : i \in \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}\} \cup \{C\} \cup \mathcal{D}$, define two three-uniform hypergraphs by

$$\begin{aligned} E(H_1) &= \bigcup_i \{ \{A_i, X, Y\} : X \in \{B_i, C\}, Y \in \{B_j : j \neq i\} \cup \mathcal{D} \}, \\ E(H_2) &= \bigcup_i \{ \{B_i, X, Y\} : X \in \{A_{i+1}, C\}, Y \in \{A_j : j \neq i+1\} \cup \mathcal{D} \}. \end{aligned}$$

All subscripts are read modulo n . Define

$$E(G_n) = \{\mathcal{W} \cup \{U\} \cup e : e \in E(H_1)\} \cup \{\mathcal{W} \cup \{V\} \cup e : e \in E(H_2)\} \cup \{\{U, V\} \cup \mathcal{D}\}. \quad (2.1)$$

Thus G_n is a simple 8-uniform hypergraph.

Use lower-case letters for the weights of the corresponding vertices, and write

$$A = \sum_i a_i, \quad B = \sum_i b_i, \quad D = \sum_{j=1}^6 d_j, \quad \omega = \prod_{j=1}^4 w_j.$$

The two cubic forms and the polynomial of G_n are

$$P_1 = \sum_i a_i(b_i + c)(B - b_i + D), \quad (2.2)$$

$$P_2 = \sum_i b_i(a_{i+1} + c)(A - a_{i+1} + D), \quad (2.3)$$

$$P_{G_n} = \omega(uP_1 + vP_2) + uv \prod_{j=1}^6 d_j. \quad (2.4)$$

Lemma 3. *The lower bound in (1.2) holds.*

Proof. Assign the weights

$$w_j = \frac{1}{8}, \quad u = v = \frac{1}{16}, \quad a_i = b_i = \frac{1}{8n}, \quad d_j = \frac{1}{48n}, \quad c = \frac{n-1}{8n}. \quad (2.5)$$

Their sum is one. Moreover,

$$A = B = c + D = \frac{1}{8}, \quad b_i + c = B - b_i + D = a_{i+1} + c = A - a_{i+1} + D = \frac{1}{8}.$$

Thus $P_1 = P_2 = 8^{-3}$. The first term in (2.4) is 8^{-8} , and the second is

$$\frac{1}{256(48n)^6} = \frac{8^{-8}}{4(6n)^6}. \quad \square$$

3 A bound for open paths

We first prove an inequality for the cubic forms obtained by opening the cycle.

Lemma 4. *Let $L \geq 1$, and let $a_1, \dots, a_L, b_1, \dots, b_L, c, D$ be nonnegative numbers. Put*

$$A = \sum_{i=1}^L a_i, \quad B = \sum_{i=1}^L b_i, \quad a_{L+1} = 0,$$

and suppose that $A + B + c + D = 1$. Define P_1, P_2 by (2.2) and (2.3), with sums over $1 \leq i \leq L$. Then, for every $s \in [0, 1]$,

$$sP_1 + (1-s)P_2 \leq \frac{1}{27} - \frac{s(1-s)D^3}{1200}. \quad (3.1)$$

Proof. Set

$$\delta_A = A - \frac{1}{3}, \quad \delta_B = B - \frac{1}{3},$$

and

$$\begin{aligned} \beta &= \frac{B + D - c}{2} = D + \frac{\delta_A}{2} + \delta_B, \\ \alpha &= \frac{A + D - c}{2} = D + \delta_A + \frac{\delta_B}{2}. \end{aligned}$$

Completing the square gives

$$P_1 = \frac{A(1-A)^2}{4} - \sum_i a_i (b_i - \beta)^2, \quad (3.2)$$

$$P_2 = \frac{B(1-B)^2}{4} - \sum_i b_i (a_{i+1} - \alpha)^2. \quad (3.3)$$

If

$$E = s \sum_i a_i (b_i - \beta)^2 + (1-s) \sum_i b_i (a_{i+1} - \alpha)^2,$$

then (3.2)–(3.3) give the exact identity

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{27} - sP_1 - (1-s)P_2 &= \frac{s\delta_A^2(4/3-A)}{4} + \frac{(1-s)\delta_B^2(4/3-B)}{4} + E \\ &\geq \frac{s\delta_A^2 + (1-s)\delta_B^2}{12} + E, \end{aligned} \quad (3.4)$$

since $0 \leq A, B \leq 1$.

Case 1: $D = 0$ or $s \in \{0, 1\}$. The right side of (3.1) is then $1/27$, so the claim follows immediately from (3.4).

Case 2: one of $|\delta_A|, |\delta_B|$ is at least $D/10$. Assume first that $|\delta_A| \geq D/10$. Since $D \leq 1$,

$$\frac{s\delta_A^2}{12} \geq \frac{sD^2}{1200} \geq \frac{s(1-s)D^3}{1200}.$$

The case $|\delta_B| \geq D/10$ is the same.

Case 3: $|\delta_A|, |\delta_B| < D/10$. Here

$$D \leq c + D = \frac{1}{3} - \delta_A - \delta_B \leq \frac{1}{3} + \frac{D}{5},$$

so $D \leq 5/12$. It follows that

$$\frac{17D}{20} \leq \alpha, \beta \leq \frac{23D}{20} \leq \frac{23}{48}, \quad A, B \geq \frac{1}{3} - \frac{D}{10} \geq \frac{7}{24}. \quad (3.5)$$

In particular, $\alpha, \beta > 0$, $A \geq \alpha/3$, and $B \geq \beta/3$.

Consider the finite sequence

$$\frac{a_1}{\alpha}, \frac{b_1}{\beta}, \dots, \frac{a_L}{\alpha}, \frac{b_L}{\beta}, 0. \quad (3.6)$$

Each successive pair z, z' contributes to E a term

$$s\alpha\beta^2 z(z' - 1)^2 \quad \text{or} \quad (1-s)\beta\alpha^2 z(z' - 1)^2,$$

according as the first entry comes from an a_i or a b_i . *Case 3a: some entry of (3.6) is at least $1/3$.* Because the last entry is zero, some successive pair satisfies $z \geq 1/3$ and $z' < 1/3$. Hence

$$E \geq \frac{4}{27} \min\{s\alpha\beta^2, (1-s)\beta\alpha^2\}. \quad (3.7)$$

Case 3b: all entries of (3.6) are less than $1/3$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} E &\geq \frac{4}{9}(s\beta^2 A + (1-s)\alpha^2 B) \\ &\geq \frac{4}{27}(s\alpha\beta^2 + (1-s)\beta\alpha^2), \end{aligned}$$

which also implies (3.7). Using (3.5), we obtain in either case

$$E \geq \frac{4}{27} \left(\frac{17}{20}\right)^3 \min\{s, 1-s\} D^3 \geq \frac{s(1-s)D^3}{1200}.$$

The last inequality follows from $\frac{4}{27}(\frac{17}{20})^3 = 4913/54000 > 1/1200$. Together with (3.4), this proves the lemma. $\square$

For $L \geq 1$, define the 8-uniform hypergraph T_L as in (2.1), with each index ranging over $1, \dots, L$ and with the last link in H_2 replaced by the triples

$$\{B_L, C, Y\}, \quad Y \in \{A_1, \dots, A_L\} \cup \mathcal{D}.$$

The edge $\{U, V\} \cup \mathcal{D}$ is retained. Its polynomial is (2.4) with $a_{L+1} = 0$.

Lemma 5. *For every $L \geq 1$, we have $\lambda(T_L) = 8^{-8}$.*

Proof. The lower bound follows by assigning weight $1/8$ to the vertices of any one edge and zero elsewhere. For the upper bound, take nonnegative vertex weights of total mass one, and put

$$h = \sum_{j=1}^4 w_j, \quad q = u + v, \quad t = A + B + c + D.$$

Thus $h + q + t = 1$. If $q = 0$ or $t = 0$, then $P_{T_L} = 0$. Otherwise put

$$s = u/q, \quad d = D/t, \quad z = s(1-s)d^3 \in [0, 1/4].$$

Applying Lemma 4 to the bottom weights divided by t , and then using homogeneity, gives

$$uP_1 + vP_2 \leq qt^3 \left(\frac{1}{27} - \frac{z}{1200} \right).$$

The arithmetic-geometric mean inequality now yields

$$P_{T_L} \leq \left(\frac{h}{4}\right)^4 qt^3 \left(\frac{1}{27} - \frac{z}{1200} \right) + q^2 s(1-s) \left(\frac{td}{6}\right)^6. \quad (3.8)$$

Also,

$$\frac{qt^3}{27} \leq \left(\frac{q+t}{4}\right)^4, \quad \frac{q^2 t^6}{6^6} \leq 4 \left(\frac{q+t}{8}\right)^8. \quad (3.9)$$

Define

$$F(h) = 256h^4(1-h)^4.$$

We have $F(h) \leq 1$, with equality at $h = 1/2$. Since $1 - 27z/1200 > 0$, we may substitute (3.9) into (3.8). Using $d^6 \leq d^3$, we get

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{P_{T_L}}{8^{-8}} &\leq F(h) \left(1 - \frac{9}{400}z\right) + 4s(1-s)d^6(1-h)^8 \\ &\leq F(h) + z \left[4(1-h)^8 - \frac{9}{400}F(h)\right]. \end{aligned} \quad (3.10)$$

It remains to show that

$$\left(1 - \frac{9}{1600}\right)F(h) + (1-h)^8 \leq 1 \quad (0 \leq h \leq 1). \quad (3.11)$$

Indeed, the last expression in (3.10) is the convex combination

$$(1-4z)F(h) + 4z \left[\left(1 - \frac{9}{1600}\right)F(h) + (1-h)^8\right].$$

The endpoints of (3.11) are immediate. For $0 < h < 1$, put $x = h/(1-h) > 0$. Expanding gives

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{(1+x)^8 - 1}{x^4} &= x^4 + 8(x^3 + x^{-3}) + 28(x^2 + x^{-2}) + 56(x + x^{-1}) + 70 \\ &\geq 139 + 60x + 56x^{-1} \\ &\geq 139 + 2\sqrt{3360} > \frac{6364}{25}. \end{aligned}$$

Here the first inequality uses $x^4 \geq 4x - 3$ and $x^j + x^{-j} \geq 2$ for $j = 2, 3$, all consequences of AM-GM; the second is another application of AM-GM. The final comparison follows by squaring, since $2889^2 < 4 \cdot 3360 \cdot 25^2$. Multiplying by $x^4/(1+x)^8$ proves (3.11), because $256(1 - 9/1600) = 6364/25$. This completes the upper bound. $\square$

4 The Lagrangian bound and the blow-ups

Proof of Proposition 2. The lower bound was proved in Lemma 3. For the upper bound, take any nonnegative weights on G_n of total mass one. Choose an index k with

$$a_k + b_k \leq \frac{A+B}{n} \leq \frac{1}{n}.$$

Put $a'_j = a_{k+j}$, $b'_j = b_{k+j}$ for $1 \leq j \leq n-1$, with indices modulo n , and set $A' = \sum_j a'_j$, $B' = \sum_j b'_j$, $a'_n = 0$. After deleting A_k, B_k , the remaining polynomial is

$$\begin{aligned} P_{G_n - \{A_k, B_k\}} &= \omega u \sum_{j=1}^{n-1} a'_j(b'_j + c)(B' - b'_j + D) \\ &\quad + \omega v \sum_{j=1}^{n-1} b'_j(a'_{j+1} + c)(A' - a'_{j+1} + D) + uv \prod_{\ell=1}^6 d_\ell \\ &= P_{T_{n-1}}. \end{aligned} \quad (4.1)$$

Thus Lemma 5 and homogeneity bound the total weight of the edges that remain by

$$8^{-8}(1 - a_k - b_k)^8 \leq 8^{-8}.$$

For any simple 8-uniform hypergraph and weights of total mass one,

$$\frac{\partial P_H}{\partial x_v} \leq \sum_{\substack{S \subseteq V(H) \setminus \{v\} \\ |S|=7}} \prod_{w \in S} x_w \leq \frac{(\sum_{w \neq v} x_w)^7}{7!} \leq \frac{1}{7!}. \quad (4.2)$$

Indeed, each product of seven distinct weights occurs $7!$ times in the power expansion, and all other terms are nonnegative. The deleted edges consequently have total weight at most

$$a_k \frac{\partial P_{G_n}}{\partial a_k} + b_k \frac{\partial P_{G_n}}{\partial b_k} \leq \frac{a_k + b_k}{7!} \leq \frac{1}{7!n}.$$

This proves (1.2). □

Proof of Theorem 1. Fix $\gamma > 8^{-8}$, and choose an integer $n \geq 2$ such that

$$8^{-8} + \frac{1}{7!n} < \gamma.$$

Keep n fixed, and set

$$\varepsilon = \frac{1}{4(6n)^6} > 0.$$

For each positive integer M , form a blow-up $B_{n,M}$ of G_n : replace each vertex by an independent class, and each edge by all transversal edges across its eight classes. Use the following class sizes, with one class for each listed vertex:

vertex	W_j	U, V	A_i, B_i	C	D_j
class size	$6nM$	$3nM$	$6M$	$6(n-1)M$	M

There are $N = 48nM$ vertices. These class sizes are proportional to the weights in (2.5), and the computation in Lemma 3 gives the exact edge count

$$e(B_{n,M}) = [(6n)^8 + 9n^2]M^8 = (1 + \varepsilon)(N/8)^8. \quad (4.3)$$

Let S be any nonempty set of m vertices of $B_{n,M}$, and let k_v be the number of its vertices in the class corresponding to $v \in V(G_n)$. Then

$$e(B_{n,M}[S]) = \sum_{e \in E(G_n)} \prod_{v \in e} k_v = m^8 P_{G_n}((k_v/m)_v) \leq m^8 \lambda(G_n) < \gamma m^8.$$

Together with (4.3) and $M \rightarrow \infty$, this proves the theorem. A non-induced subgraph has no more edges than the induced subgraph on the same vertex set. □

Corollary 6. *For every integer $r \geq 8$ and every $\gamma > r^{-r}$, there is an $\varepsilon > 0$ and there are arbitrarily large r -uniform hypergraphs H such that*

$$e(H) \geq (1 + \varepsilon)(v(H)/r)^r, \quad e(H[S]) < \gamma |S|^r \quad \text{for every nonempty } S \subseteq V(H).$$

In particular, Problem 1075 fails for every $r \geq 8$.

Proof. This is the lifting step of Peng [6]; in the present normalization it has the following direct form. Let $q = r - 8$. For a 8-uniform hypergraph G , form an r -uniform hypergraph G^{+q} by adjoining the same set of q new vertices to every edge. If the total weight on $V(G)$ is t , then the arithmetic–geometric mean inequality gives

$$P_{G^{+q}} \leq \lambda(G)t^8 \left(\frac{1-t}{q} \right)^q,$$

with the usual interpretation when $q = 0$. The right side is maximized at $t = 8/r$, and equality is attained by taking an optimal weighting of G , scaled by $8/r$, and weight $1/r$ on each new vertex. Hence

$$\lambda(G^{+q}) = \frac{8^8}{r^r} \lambda(G). \quad (4.4)$$

Applying (4.4) to G_n and using Proposition 2 gives

$$r^{-r} \left(1 + \frac{1}{4(6n)^6} \right) \leq \lambda(G_n^{+q}) \leq r^{-r} + \frac{8^8}{r^r 7! n}.$$

Choose n so that the upper bound is less than γ . The blow-up argument in the proof of Theorem 1, using the rational weighting obtained by suspending (2.5), then gives the stated r -uniform hypergraphs with $\varepsilon = 1/[4(6n)^6]$. $\square$

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

OpenAI Codex (GPT-6 Astra) was used to generate the mathematical proofs, draft the manuscript, and write the Lean formalization. GPT-5.6 Sol and Claude Opus 5 were used only for editorial review of the exposition. The author reviewed the final manuscript and takes full responsibility for its content.

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